

DOCTOR WHO?

I have big-ass teeth, and over the past two decades, my gums had been receding. Whenever I used to eat anything particularly hot or cold, they would sting something awful. The only solution for this was gum graft surgery. So in mid-December 2015, with a full-time job and a good insurance plan, I finally got it done. But even with insurance, this procedure cost me approximately \$7,000 (!), money I didn't have or expect to have anytime soon. After losing my shit over the bill, I signed up for a medical debt service called CareCredit that allowed me to pay \$50 a month, which at the time I assumed I'd continue doing until I died. But, hey, at least I could eat soup without crying.

In January 2017, NPR reported on a study by the Federal Consumer Financial Protection Bureau that found that more than half the people contacted by debt collectors said it was “for medical services.”

Although it's a serious problem that merits discussion, medical debt feels like fodder for old-person dinner conversation once you've run out of small talk about PBS or NPR's programming. It's also inherently shameful. There's an amazing Web comic by artist Sarah Winifred Searle about her experience going into medical debt because she was ashamed to tell her parents about needing money to pay for HPV treatments. But even if the problem isn't genital-based, it's hard to admit you're going into debt over a medical issue.

My friend the comedian H. Alan Scott is outspoken about this part of his life. Scott was diagnosed with testicular cancer a week after his 30th birthday. When he was diagnosed, he was living in NYC and had a full-time job doing social media for an event planning company. Luckily, he had insurance through his job, which he'd used only a couple of times to see a dentist. But as he found out the hard way, insurance doesn't cover everything. He is now in remission, with about \$80,000 in medical debt. Scott said he doesn't answer the phone if he doesn't recognize the number (to avoid debt collectors). His “plan” for paying it